Health Data Research -West Africa (HDRWA) Platform: Data Access Guidelines Version: 23 MARCH 2023

The Data Access Committee ("DAC") will follow these Guidelines when evaluating applications to access data held on the HDRWA Platform ("Platform Data"). All approved applications will have a Data Use Agreement signed by the Data Requestor and the platform host (MRCG at LSHTM) before the data are made accessible.

Application

Each Data Requestor will submit a Data Access Application in the form set out in Annex 1 to these Guidelines.

Presumption of Approval

If an application complies with these Guidelines and there are no concerns of scientific value or ethics, then there is a rebuttable presumption that the application will be approved by the DAC.

Conflict of Interest

Data Requestors must submit a completed declaration of interests form with the application and agree to notify the DAC and Secretariat of any changes. A copy of the declaration of interests form is appended to the Application.

The Platform Data Access Process

- All applications will be processed by Secretariat and the Data Access Committee in accordance with these Guidelines.
- There is no fee or other cost for Data Requestors to access the Platform Data.
- The DAC will respond within 2 months (via the Secretariat). In the case of an application for data access that is relevant to ongoing public health emergency, an expedited procedure will be undertaken to return a DAC response as soon as possible.
- The DAC may source the opinion of the independent experts to inform their decision. In the case that this extends the review period, the Data Requestor will be informed.
- The DAC can decide to:
    - approve the application;
    - approve the application subject to the Data Requestor obtaining funding and/or necessary approvals from the national ethical boards of the relevant countries;
    - ask for further clarification or amendment by the Data Requestor;
    - if the application does not meet these Guidelines reject the application;
- The DAC will provide written justification for all rejected applications.
- Rejected applications and those for which amendments are requested will be reconsidered if the issues raised by the DAC are addressed in a subsequent application. Disputes and/or appeals regarding the data access decisions will be managed by the Data Access Committee in the first instance and, if required, may be referred to the Steering Committee for advice.
- The DAC defines the data sets to be released.

Platform Data Protection

No personal/ identifiable data will be transferred or otherwise made available to Data Requestors.

Review considerations

Applications will be evaluated according to the following criteria:

Benefits Sharing

Applications must include initiatives on how to build local research capability in low -resource settings by providing benefits to already-fragile public health systems. Examples of such initiatives may include some or all of the following:

- the application is led by, or includes collaborative partnerships with the research community in a low-resource setting,
- the application develops research capacity in countries of the origin of the data,
- the application has a strategy to share knowledge directly with regional/national health authorities
- the application includes plans to acknowledge and accredit the data contributors

Scientific value

The DAC will ensure that the proposal has scientific value by verifying that the scientific question:

- address a knowledge gap and avoid duplication and unnecessary competition,
- benefits the wider public health community.
- Plans to publish and disseminate the research results
- must enable access to the results by HDRWA.

Scientific Validity

The Platform Data requested must be capable of answering the research question.

The methodology proposed to answer the research question must be sound.

Applications to the Platform must not request more than the minimum Platform Data necessary to answer the research question – each variable requested must be required for the successful completion of the research (proportionality and minimization).

Researchers

Access to Platform Data is limited to Data Requestors working in a field relevant to the application and with a formal affiliation to a health, research, humanitarian, government, inter-government or academic institution with legal status.

The Data Requestor will attest that sufficient funding to perform the proposed research has been secured or is being sought for this purpose.

The Data Requestor will not have previously violated any of the requirements for data access outlined in these Guidelines or any Data Use Agreement.

Ethics

The DAC must be satisfied that there are no concerns with respect to the ethical aspects of the application

Conflict of Interest

The DAC must consider any conflicts of interest declared and ensure that they do not risk compromise of the quality or integrity of the proposed use of Platform Data.

Approvals

All required scientific and ethical reviews and/or approvals must be obtained before the Data Use Agreement is signed and before any Platform Data is disclosed to the Data Requestor.

The Data Requestor must have the necessary legal, scientific and ethical approvals from the Data Requestor's country; **and** either:

- the application has been approved by the ethics boards of the country(ies) from where data requested originates, or
- the application will be submitted by the Data Requestor for approval to the ethical boards of the country(ies) from where Platform Data requested originates once approved by the Platform and before data are released.

Platform Data Use Agreement

Before any Platform Data is disclosed, Data Requestors will be required to enter a standard Data Use Agreement with MRCG at LSHTM imposing obligations on the Data Requestor that are intended to ensure compliance with the key principles underpinning the Platform.

Annex 1

HDRWA Platform - Data Access Application Form

Please review the Data Access Guidelines and the Data Use Agreement before completing this form. A complete application should address all of the Review Considerations outlined in the Data Access Guidelines. Note that the details of all approved applications will be made publicly available on the HDRWA Platform website.

Complete all sections of this form fully and return to hdrwa@mrc.gm.

SECTION A: RESEARCHER / RESEARCH TEAM INFORMATION	
Lead Applicant Details	
Title	
First name (given name)	
Surname (family name)	
Gender	
Position at employing organisation/ institution	
ORCID ID (https://orcid.org) or URL to academic profile	*(if no ORCID or URL, please attach a short academic CV)*
Email	
Employing Organisation/Institution *Institution with a remit including health, research or academic pursuit, and with legal status which includes the scope to sign the **Data Use Agreement.***	
Institution name	
City, Country	
Does your institution agree to execute the Data Use Agreement? (if your application is approved)	**YES/NO** (delete as appropriate)
Co-applicants *ALL individuals accessing the data must be listed on this form. Any later additions must be notified to HDRWA and the Data Access Committee. Add rows as necessary.*	
1. Name	
1. Position / Role in analysis	
1. Organisation/Institution	
2. Name	
2. Position / Role in analysis	
2. Organisation/Institution	
3. Name	
3. Position / Role in analysis	
3. Organisation/Institution	
Conflicts of Interest *List details of any existing or perceived conflicts of interest (financial or non-financial) that exist relating to the use of the requested data by the data requestor and/or co-applicants (see ICMJE.org for the definition of conflicts of interest).*	

SECTION B: RESEARCH PLAN	
Title of Proposed Research	
Is this a re-submission of a previous application to HDRA that has already been reviewed? ***[If yes, provide the submission date of the previous application]***	
Summary of Research in Lay Language *(suggested maximum 100 words)*	
Summary of Research Objectives and Scientific Value *(suggested maximum 400 words)*	
Primary and Secondary Outcome Measures *(suggested maximum 200 words)*	
Proposed Methodology and Statistical Analysis Plan *(suggested maximum 400 words)*	
Ethics *(suggested maximum 300 words)* *Provide details of any ethical considerations relating to the research proposal.* *Additionally, list any approvals required by your institution to undertake this work, list reference numbers of any approved proposals, or explain why no approvals are required.*	
Publication and Dissemination Plan *(suggested maximum 300 words)* *Provide details of plans for authorship/acknowledgement of data contributors.* *Provide details of timelines for publication and dissemination of research findings.*	
Research Priorities Addressed (*suggested maximum 300 words)* *Provide details of how this research aligns with nationally or internationally set research priorities.*	
Collaboration and Knowledge Sharing *(suggested maximum 300 words)* *Provide details of how this research will collaborate, support and/or share knowledge with appropriate partners. The platform is particularly interested in research that builds capacity in low-resource settings.*	

Funding *(suggested maximum 100 words)*
Provide details of how this research will be funded/resourced. Please name the source of funding.

Scientific Review *(suggested maximum 200 words)*
If the project has been scientifically reviewed, please provide details. This could be by your institution, a funder/donor or review committee.

SECTION C: DATA

Data Variables
Please provide a list of studies, data variables and/or description/parameters for the data you require to complete your analysis. Include parameters to check eligibility criteria (e.g. pregnancy status).